

Press Releases

Quirch Foods Announces Leadership Transition

March 17th, 2026

MIAMI–(BUSINESS WIRE)–Quirch Foods, LLC, a portfolio company of Palladium Equity Partners, today announced that, as part of the company’s long-term succession plan, Frank Grande will transition from his role as Chief Executive Officer effective April 1, 2026.

After years of transformational leadership, Grande leaves behind a strong legacy of growth and evolution at Quirch Foods. During his tenure, he led the company through significant expansion, including broadening its national footprint, completing strategic acquisitions, strengthening key customer partnerships, modernizing systems and infrastructure, and building a leadership team positioned for long-term success.

Effective April 1, 2026, Joe Ward, currently President and Chief Operating Officer, will assume the role of President and Chief Executive Officer. Ward has been a key member of Quirch’s leadership team, and the transition has been thoughtfully planned to ensure continuity, stability, and continued momentum for the business.

Ward brings nearly three decades of leadership experience in the food and distribution industries. He holds a Bachelor of Science in Economics from the University of Scranton and an MBA from the University of Miami. He began his career with PepsiCo, spent more than 15 years leading food manufacturing organizations, and later held roles of increasing responsibility during a decade with Bunzl Distribution North America. He joined Quirch Foods as Chief Operating Officer in late 2024 and was named President in 2025.

“It’s an honor to step into the role of President and CEO of Quirch Foods,” said Ward. “Frank has built an extraordinary organization grounded in strong relationships, entrepreneurial spirit, and a culture that values people and performance. I look forward to building on that foundation as we continue investing in our team, our capabilities, and the next phase of growth.”

Grande will remain actively involved with the company as a member of the Board of Directors and Chairman of the Board’s Mergers & Acquisitions Committee. In this role, he will continue supporting strategic growth initiatives, acquisition opportunities, and key customer and partner relationships.

“It has been a privilege to serve as CEO of Quirch Foods,” said Grande. “I am incredibly proud of what our team has accomplished together. With strong leadership in place and a clear strategy for the future, I look forward to supporting the company’s continued growth in this next chapter.”

About Quirch Foods

Founded in 1967, Quirch Foods is a food distribution company serving large and independent retailers, foodservice providers, and cruise line businesses across the United States, the Caribbean, and Central and South America. With one of the most comprehensive brand portfolios for a distributor of its type and size, Quirch operates 24 distribution facilities throughout the United States and Puerto Rico, representing a combined 2.4 million square feet of refrigerated warehouse space and a fleet of more than 400 trucks. Quirch Foods® is the exclusive distributor of Chiquita® Brands frozen tropical fruits, Panamei Seafood®, High River Angus®, Kikiriquirch® poultry, Mambo Foods®, and a licensed distributor of Certified Angus Beef®. For more information, visit www.quirchfoods.com, follow us on Facebook, Instagram, and LinkedIn, or call (800) 458-5252. Quirch Foods is a portfolio company of Palladium Equity Partners.

About Palladium Equity Partners, LLC

Palladium is a private equity firm with over \$3 billion of assets under management. The firm invests in the middle market, focusing on companies in the U.S. Hispanic market, founder and family-owned businesses, and those with accretive M&A opportunities. The partners of the firm have significant experience in the consumer, services, industrials, and healthcare sectors. Since its founding in 1997, Palladium has invested in more than 240 businesses, including 41 platforms and over 200 add-ons. For more information, visit www.palladiumequity.com.

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